She Means Business: Empowering Female Entrepreneurs

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Introduction

"She Means Business: Empowering Female Entrepreneurs" is a CSR partnership initiative geared toward helping women-led small businesses in Africa and South Asia grow and succeed. Through giving women the tools they need, such as financial skills, access to small loans, and strong support networks, this program will allow locals in underserved communities to gain the self-efficacy to build businesses and gain economic independence. Additionally, by offering culturally-tailored training, funding, and support toward stakeholders in these communities, this program aims to help women overcome the disparities that often limit their ability to succeed in the business scope long-term.

This effort is a partnership between two of the most significant MNCs and NGOs in the world: Absa, a prominent financial and banking company based in South Africa, and BRAC, a global nonprofit known for its local presence and work for fighting poverty and inequality. In this initiative, Absa brings financial knowledge and resources, while BRAC works towards connecting with communities and understanding local needs. By working together, both companies can tackle the major problem of gender inequality in the business scope of underserved communities. By teaming up, there is major potential to make real progress toward reducing both economic and gender inequality.

"She Means Business" presses toward the goal of tackling the ongoing issue of gender-based economic inequality, specifically focusing on supporting female entrepreneurs in Africa and South Asia who lack access to basic financial tools, business education, or reliable support systems. When female entrepreneurs are missing these key factors, the act of growing a business or achieving financial independence can seem nearly impossible. This partnership works to fight against three significant challenges that affect women daily: poverty, lack of education, and

gender inequality. These are very real issues that show up in real, everyday life that hold women back from building proper livelihoods and thriving in their businesses.

Rationale

In many areas of Africa and South Asia, women play a very important role in local economies. They often run small businesses that help feed, clothe, and educate their families. In fact, Africa actually holds the highest proportion of female entrepreneurial activity in the world (24%), due to these factors (Hopps, 2024). These women are incredibly resourceful, but they're working within systems that are often unable to support them properly. They often lack access to basic financial services like bank accounts, loans, or insurance. In Bangladesh, the disparity between male and female bank account usage is over 20% (IFC, 2023). Additionally, according to the International Monetary Fund, women in sub-Saharan Africa are 11% less likely than men to have a bank account, and far less likely to get access to the kinds of financial products that could help their businesses grow (Morsy, 2020). This is an issue because when one is unable to save money, take out a loan, or protect oneself against setbacks, it's almost impossible to grow or sustain a business.

However, simple access to money is not the only challenge. Many women in these areas face serious barriers in terms of education. Statistics show that over 90 million adult women in sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia are illiterate (UNESCO, n.d.). That means many lack the proper schooling to complete business tasks such as reading a banking document, filling out a loan application, or taking part in existing business training. This disparity of literacy does not just block access to opportunities, but may also affect self-confidence and decision making. To address this, "She Means Business" uses teaching methods that do not rely on traditional reading

and writing skills, striving to achieve educational equity for all women taking part in the program.

In many communities, women still carry a majority of the caregiving responsibilities. They may need to ask permission from male family members to attend training or start a business due to local laws and cultural traditions. Social norms often discourage or prevent women from working outside the home. In order to fight against the social norms put upon women, “She Means Business” offers childcare during training sessions, brings in male allies to support women’s goals, and works with communities to shift the narrative around what women can and should do in the economy. By doing so, She Means Business helps more women participate and fights for long term change in communities.

Ultimately, “She Means Business” intends to push the narrative that when women succeed economically, everyone benefits. The World Food Program USA reports that women do 2.6 times more unpaid care and domestic work than men do and earn 23% less for paid work. Yet when they do earn an income, they reinvest 90% of their resources back into their families and communities which creates stronger families and stronger communities (WFP USA, n.d.). However, for empowerment to be meaningful, there has to be more than just a one time grant or workshop. The kind of long-term change the partnership seeks requires consistent support, education, mentorship, and community engagement, all of which are built into this program.

That’s why Absa and BRAC make such a strong team. Absa has the financial abilities and power to influence how banks and companies work with women and BRAC has decades of experience working directly with underserved communities and understands the daily realities women face. Together, they are a partnership that works, creating a bridge between corporate tools and real world needs.

Operationalization

"She Means Business" is not just about helping women open bank accounts or start small businesses. It's about challenging and changing the systems that have excluded women from full participation in economic life for decades. By aiming to tackle financial illiteracy, lack of access to resources, and cultural expectations all at once, this partnership offers a multi-pronged model of CSR that goes beyond just "good intentions." The goal is not just about doing good, it's about doing good thoughtfully, effectively, and with purpose.

The "She Means Business" project is put into action through a community-based approach with the goal of creating real difference in the present in order to field long-term change for the future. The primary stakeholders who will benefit from this initiative are women running small businesses in underdeveloped regions of South Asia and Africa, especially those who don't have access to banks, business training, or supportive networks. But the benefits from this project also reach further by helping families, communities, nonprofits, etc. through building stronger local economies and encouraging shared support for women's successes globally.

The project employs a multi-pronged approach that plays out in four stages that build upon each other. First, Absa and BRAC will work together to create a financial literacy program that makes sense for the women' s unique social and cultural situations. BRAC will lead in training local women and organizing community meetings with trusted leaders, women's groups, and nonprofits to gain trust and seek out potential participants for the program. In the second stage, the women will be attending hands-on and interactive workshops where they will learn the basics of running a business, such as how to budget, set prices, and save money. These workshops will be made easy to join and understand based on each group of women's current levels of literacy, business experience, and familial support. In the third stage, women begin

putting their learning into action. This stage will teach them how to develop their own business plans and receive microloans loans from Absa to get started or to grow. These women will also be brought together with more experienced women entrepreneurs for mentoring and group meetings will be held where they can ask questions, share success stories, and support one another which will hopefully create a sense of community for them. In order to measure success, the final stage will be centered around checking in and helping the women continue to succeed. BRAC follows up with surveys and visits to see how businesses are doing, where the training could be improved, and if any follow up support is needed.

"She Means Business" hopes to achieve financial and personal growth for the women involved. The project wants to see at least half of the participants using banking tools and noticeable income growth within their first year. Another goal the project aims to see is for the women to feel more confident handling money, to become more independent, and to stay committed to running their businesses long term. To measure success, the team will use a mix of surveys taken before and after the program, financial tracking tools to see any growth, and check if mentoring relationships continue after the program ends. A big part of this project is also looking at how many women keep running their businesses and supporting each other without outside/extra help. All these tools are in place to make sure that She Means Business isn't just another corporate program, but a powerful and lasting way to create real opportunities for women and build more inclusive economies.

Partnership Justification

The "She Means Business" CSR initiative is strategically aligned with the missions, capabilities, and interests of both the NGO and MNC involved, BRAC and Absa. For BRAC, supporting women has always been at the heart of their organization's values. As one of the

world's largest and most highly recognized NGO's, BRAC has a deep commitment to poverty alleviation, education, and gender empowerment across South Asia and Africa, bringing both a sense of deep rooted community trust among stakeholders and strong practical operational infrastructure. BRAC's proven track record of implementing a successful and sustainable grassroots approach into their philanthropic efforts makes it well suited to carry out, organize, and facilitate education, culturally-informed outreach, and community-driven initiatives (Zalkin, 2011). It can be trusted that BRAC's familiarity with cultural boundaries and alignment with the Stakeholder Involvement Strategy approach will ensure that the program will be suited to local community needs to maximize engagement and impact (BRAC USA, 2022).

In addition, Absa, an established pan-African banking and insurance firm has both the financial coverage and heart to ensure that this operation will result in success. Absa is highly reputable in their values towards empowering underserved populations across Africa, women in particular. They have been recognized for these efforts several times before, such as being cited by Forbes as "one of the World's Top Female-friendly Companies for 2022" and being "top 40 companies worldwide in championing gender equality." As for financial reputation, Absa also has a well backed-up track record, citing their work with the UN to provide funding to female owned businesses, showcasing an incredible 166% growth in revenue for the women in their program (Absa Group, 2023).

Absa has even launched a brand new microloaning system called Digiloan as of 2025, which would be perfectly suited to the financial aid aspect of "She Means Business" (Twaha, 2025). This initiative will give Absa the opportunity to both advance their commitment towards marginalized communities while simultaneously cultivating a future customer base among microentrepreneurs.

Overall, “She Means Business” is able to leverage itself on a strong resource synergy perspective between the two organizations, with each bringing to the table what the other cannot provide in order to achieve their mutual goal of female empowerment. Absa is able to provide financial assistance and technological support that an NGO may not have access to on their own, as well as expansive corporate communication channels to reach out to for additional financial aid, branding, and marketing to ensure that the program is a success. On the other hand, BRAC brings expansive first-hand community knowledge and relations toward stakeholders, allowing Absa to tap into communities that may be more isolated and also deepen their own trust among stakeholders as a sustainable and socially responsible brand. In other words, Absa enables access to financial products, while BRAC ensures that the women in the program are equipped to use those tools effectively.

What makes “She Means Business” different from other CSR initiatives in the financial literacy sector is the multi-pronged approach that successfully incorporates financial education, microloans, and mentorship under one culturally-adapted model. Compared to previous partnerships, for example Absa’s ReadyToWork program, which provided virtual webinars on Facebook and YouTube geared toward aspiring business students aged 15-24, “She Means Business” will provide outreach to more remote communities that may not have the access to such technologies or schooling to obtain access to webinars, as our program will focus on aiding women who may have limited literacy skills or live in areas with technological deficiencies (Absa Group Ghana, 2024). Additionally, our program also provides financial support in the form of microloans in addition to simply education. Many programs target either literacy or funding, but “She Means Business” bridges both access and ability, helping ensure that beneficiaries not only receive capital but can also manage it confidently. The initiative’s built-in

community support elements, such as peer mentorship and local discussion circles further differentiate it by reinforcing long-term empowerment beyond program delivery.

Evaluation

To assess the success of the “She Means Business” initiative, both quantitative and qualitative Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) will be used. These metrics are structured around three main dimensions: financial outcomes, empowerment outcomes, and sustainability outcomes.

Financial KPIs include:

- A loan repayment rate of at least 85% within the first six months of disbursement.
    - A high repayment rate signals that participants are not only using the loans responsibly but also generating enough income to sustain repayments. It reflects the program’s ability to promote viable, self-sustaining businesses rather than dependency or financial strain.
- A 50% increase in the use of formal banking tools among participants.
    - Increased adoption of financial tools indicates improved financial literacy and trust in formal financial systems. This aligns with Absa’s goal of financial inclusion through microloaning and ensures that participants can interact with these systems effectively.

Empowerment KPIs will seek to measure individual’s shifts in confidence and self:

- Both Pre- and Post- Program surveys will be administered to all participants to measure differences in their perceptions of confidence towards financial, business, and self-truth knowledge.

    - These surveys provide insight into internal transformations that may not be visible through financial metrics alone. These help track how the program impacts participants' mindset, agency, and long-term planning abilities. If participants do not feel motivated or confident to continue their businesses down the line, the program cannot be marked as a sustainable one.
- Discussion groups with participants to gather personal insight.
    - This qualitative data will help enforce our program's focus on community and stakeholder involvement, allowing participants to provide critical feedback towards participants satisfaction with the program's implementation to their community, allowing us to remain mindful and sensitive to the concerns of those affected.

Lastly, Sustainability KPIs will monitor the long-term benefits of the program's implementation over time:

- Retention in business: percentage of participants still operating their businesses after the program.
    - Long-term business continuity is a strong indicator of sustainable impact. This shows significant signs that the initiative leads to stable ventures, not just short-term boosts, and that the women have been provided the right tools to navigate real-world challenges.
- Number of peer mentorships and discussion circles that continue without external support from Absa and BRAC post-program end date.

- Continued peer support beyond the program life reflects real community ownership. This indicates that the knowledge and networks built are lasting, which reduces future reliance on NGO or MNC involvement over time.

Potential Challenges

Despite robust planning and high reputability from both groups involved, several challenges pose potential threats to the initiative's success.

One significant obstacle is the literacy and education barriers posed toward women in underdeveloped areas. According to the World Bank, the gap in adult literacy between men and women in South Asia is 14.8%, nearly 2.5x larger than the world aggregate, which is 6.5% (World Bank, n.d.). Due to this, many women in these regions may have issues in understanding traditional education methods such as textbook reading or note taking. As a solution, “She Means Business” seeks to break these norms to make learning more accessible for women of all schooling levels and backgrounds. “She Means Business” will bring in non-traditional learning opportunities such as using storytelling, games, and visual aids in workshops. BRAC is familiar in using such non-traditional education initiatives, such as their success in using a “show, not tell” method of video storytelling to show underserved Bangladesh residents how their medical treatment loan program (MTL+) would provide protection against health and asset vulnerability (Rahman et. al, 2021). Additionally, local translators will assist in instruction. Where appropriate, participants will be encouraged to enroll in BRAC’s existing adult literacy programs, ensuring the program not only serves immediate business needs but aids in long-lasting educational development.

Another potential challenge to be considered is the economic risks that may come from the loan distribution. Microloans have the potential to become a burden on entrepreneurs if they for whatever reason become unable to pay the loan back, may it be due to poor business performance or family emergencies. To lower this risk, Absa and BRAC will screen business plans for viability during training and offer phased disbursement. BRAC will also offer Absa guidance using their knowledge of the local communities financial systems to agree on a fair and viable interest rate to maximize the chances of successful loan repayment.

Lastly, “She Means Business” is conscious not only in its efforts to remain sensitive to existing cultural norms, but also to encourage local communities to fight for additional female rights. As aforementioned, women still lack the ability to open their own bank accounts and manage their own money independently of a man, which in many situations may lead to women becoming stuck in dangerous situations due to their financial dependence on others. As this dependence is the norm, it may be looked down upon for women to join this program, which can be very discouraging and lead to low attendance. To retroact this, “She Means Business” intends to seek the involvement of influential cultural leaders, such as religious figures, village elders, and respected community members, to publicly endorse the initiative and emphasize its benefits for entire households, not just the women involved. Through culturally informed messaging and male allyship, the program will work to reframe women’s financial independence as a communal asset rather than a threat to tradition. By embedding gender empowerment in the language of family and community well-being, the initiative aims to lower resistance and foster inclusive local buy in. These measures ensure that cultural pushback is approached not with confrontation, but with collaboration and care.

Conclusion

“She Means Business” is not simply a CSR project, but rather a step toward building a more equitable and inclusive global economy. By merging the grassroots trust and experience of BRAC with the financial expertise and infrastructure of Absa, this initiative brings together the best of both organizations to empower women entrepreneurs in underserved regions. Through culturally-tailored education, microloans, mentorship, and ongoing community engagement, the program not only provides women the tools to succeed but also reshapes the systems that have historically held them back. The path to gender and economic justice is certainly complicated, but we hope with a partnership built on shared values and strategic action, “She Means Business” demonstrates that sustainable change is possible: one woman, business, and community at a time.

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